

French Wine Labels — A Complete Visual Guide

Bordeaux · Burgundy · Champagne · Alsace · Loire · Rhône · The South · kazmicellars.com

France has no single label system — each region developed its own language over centuries. These illustrated labels show what a typical bottle from each region looks like and explain every element. Callout numbers on the label match the numbered notes.

BORDEAUX — THE CHÂTEAU SYSTEM



The estate name leads everything. The appellation tells you the grape without naming it.

1	Château Name	The estate — always the largest text. 'Château' has no quality connotation; any estate may use it.
2	Vintage	The harvest year. In Bordeaux, vintage variation is significant. Always check.
3	Classification	1855 Classification tier — Premier through 5th Growth. Only Left Bank Médoc châteaux hold this.
4	Appellation (AOC)	The commune — Margaux, Pauillac, Saint-Estèphe (Left Bank/Cab Sauv) or Pomerol, Saint-Émilion (Right Bank/Merlot). The grape is implied by the commune.
5	Estate-Bottled	'Mis en Bouteille au Château' — grown, made, and bottled by the same producer.

■ The key insight: Left Bank commune (Pauillac, Margaux, Saint-Julien, Saint-Estèphe) = Cabernet Sauvignon dominant. Right Bank commune (Pomerol, Saint-Émilion) = Merlot dominant. You will never see the grape on the label.

BURGUNDY — THE HIERARCHY SYSTEM (Two Labels, Two Levels)

The same producer can make four completely different wines — each at a different level of the hierarchy. Compare these two labels: a Grand Cru shows only the vineyard name. A Premier Cru shows village + vineyard + classification tier.

Grand Cru — vineyard name ONLY



1	Domaine	'Domaine' = grower who owns the land and makes the wine themselves. Estate production.
2	Vineyard Name ONLY	'Chambertin' alone — no village name. Grand Cru vineyards stand alone. The vineyard IS the appellation.
3	Grand Cru	The pinnacle of the Burgundy pyramid. ~33 vineyards, ~2% of production. The hierarchy level is stated explicitly.
4	Vintage	Critical in Burgundy — quality swings between years are larger than almost anywhere else.
5	AOC Declaration	'Appellation [Vineyard] Grand Cru Contrôlée.' The legal certification. Confirms this is genuinely Grand Cru.
6	Estate-Bottled	'Mis en Bouteille au Domaine' — the grower bottled it themselves. Crucial for authenticity.

Premier Cru — village + vineyard + tier



1	Domaine	The producer. In Premier Cru and Village wines, the producer's reputation matters enormously.
2	Village Name	The commune — 'Gevrey-Chambertin.' This is the appellation level: Village. The grape (Pinot Noir) is implied.
3	Vineyard Name	The specific Premier Cru vineyard — 'Les Cazetiers.' This identifies which plot within the village.
4	Premier Cru	Stated explicitly — required. Without this, it would be a Village wine.
6	AOC Declaration	'Appellation [Village] 1er Cru Contrôlée.' The legal certification at Premier Cru level.

■ **Burgundy key:** In Grand Cru, the vineyard is the brand — 'Chambertin' alone tells you everything. In Village and Régionale wines, the producer's name matters more than the label tier. A Village Gevrey-Chambertin from Rousseau beats many Premier Crus from lesser producers.

CHAMPAGNE — STYLE, DOSAGE & PRODUCER TYPE



The dosage level, NV vs Vintage, and the RM/NM code on the back tell you everything.

1	House Name	The Champagne house — the brand. Houses (NM) blend from many growers across the region to maintain a consistent style.
2	Cuvée Name	The specific blend or tier. 'Grande Cuvée' is Krug's signature NV blend. 'Prestige Cuvée' = a house's finest expression.
3	AOC: CHAMPAGNE	The appellation. Only wine from this specific region in NE France may be called Champagne. Method, grape, and geography all legally protected.
4	Dosage / Sweetness	'Brut' = dry (0–12g/L sugar). Extra Brut = drier. Brut Nature = zero added sugar. Demi-Sec = noticeably sweet. Always check this.
5	NV = Non Vintage	'Non Millésimé' or 'NV' — a multi-year blend. No vintage year on the label. Vintage Champagne shows the year and is made only in exceptional years.
6	NM Code	'NM' (Négociant-Manipulant) — a house that buys grapes. 'RM' (Récoltant-Manipulant) = a grower who makes their own wine. Look for RM for terroir-specific Champagne.

■ The back label secret: Find 'NM' or 'RM' on the back. NM = a large house blending across the region. RM = a grower making wine from their own vines. Grower Champagne is often more terroir-specific and frequently better value than famous house labels.

ALSACE — THE GRAPE LEADS (Plus Late Harvest Designations)

Alsace is the only major French region where the grape variety is the most prominent label element. This is due to Alsace's German cultural history. Compare a standard Grand Cru label with a Vendange Tardive label — the grape still leads, but the late harvest term becomes the key message.

Standard Grand Cru



1	Producer	The domaine name. In Alsace the producer matters enormously — Zind-Humbrecht, Trimbach, and Weinbach are benchmarks.
2	GRAPE VARIETY	The grape is the biggest text on an Alsace label — unique in France. Riesling = mineral/precise. Gewurztraminer = aromatic. Pinot Gris = rich. Muscat = floral.
3	Grand Cru Vineyard	The specific classified vineyard — 51 Grand Cru sites exist. Only Riesling, Gewurztraminer, Pinot Gris, and Muscat may use Grand Cru.
4	AOC Level	'Alsace Grand Cru' is the highest classification. 'AOC Alsace' is the standard designation. The level appears below the vineyard name.
5	Vintage	Important in Alsace — great vintages (2016, 2018, 2019) produce wines that age 20+ years. Late harvest designations (VT, SGN) appear here when relevant.

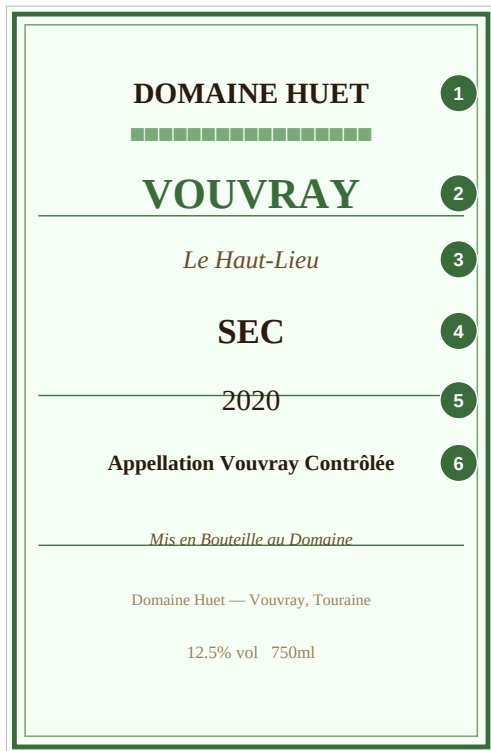
Vendange Tardive (late harvest)



1	Producer	The domaine. Weinbach (run by the Faller family) is one of Alsace's most celebrated producers of late-harvest wines.
2	GRAPE	Gewurztraminer — the grape is still front and centre, even on late-harvest wines. Alsace's rule: grape leads the label at every quality level.
3	VENDANGE TARDIVE	'Late Harvest' — grapes picked significantly later than normal, with higher sugar concentration. May be dry or sweet depending on the producer. SGN (Sélection de Grains Nobles) is richer and always sweet — botrytis-affected.
4	Vintage	Late harvest wines are only made in exceptional years — the grapes need extended hang time and dry autumn conditions.
5	AOC Level	'AOC Alsace' — not Grand Cru because the late harvest designation itself conveys the quality message. Vendange Tardive and SGN are controlled by strict harvest and sugar rules.

■ **Alsace secret:** Most Alsace wines don't state their sweetness level. Gewurztraminer and Pinot Gris often have noticeable residual sugar even without a VT designation. Look for 'sec' (dry) or ask the producer. VT = late harvest, possibly sweet. SGN = always sweet.

LOIRE VALLEY — VOUVRAY: THE MOST IMPORTANT STYLE WORD IN FRANCE



Vouvray can be bone-dry or lusciously sweet — and the label will tell you which, if you know what to look for.

1	Producer	The domaine. In Vouvray, Huet is the benchmark — one of France's greatest producers of age-worthy Chenin Blanc.
2	VOUVRAY	The appellation = the grape (Chenin Blanc, always). You will NOT see 'Chenin Blanc' on the label. Vouvray IS Chenin Blanc.
3	Vineyard / Lieu-dit	'Le Haut-Lieu' is a specific named plot — not a Grand Cru designation, just an important Huet vineyard.
4	DRY STYLE	'SEC' = bone dry. This is critical — always look for it. Without it, the wine may be off-dry or sweet. 'Demi-Sec' = noticeably sweet. 'Moelleux' = lusciously sweet.
5	Vintage	Vouvray ages magnificently — great dry Vouvrays from a producer like Huet can develop for 30–50 years.
6	AOC	'Appellation Vouvray Contrôlée' — confirms origin, variety, and method.

■ Loire key: 'Vouvray' = Chenin Blanc. Always. The grape never appears. SEC = dry. DEMI-SEC = off-dry. MOELLEUX = sweet. PÉTILLANT / MOUSSEUX = sparkling. If none of these words appears, ask the producer or check their website.

RHÔNE VALLEY — NORTH VS SOUTH: TWO DIFFERENT LABEL SYSTEMS

The two halves of the Rhône Valley label wine differently. Both show producer + appellation. Neither shows the grape variety. You must know the appellation to know the grape.

Northern Rhône — Côte-Rôtie (Syrah)



1 Producer	The négociant or estate — Guigal, Chapoutier, Jaboulet, Chave, Allemand. Producer is the brand in the Northern Rhône.
2 APPELLATION	The AOC — Côte-Rôtie, Hermitage, Crozes-Hermitage, Cornas, Saint-Joseph, Condrieu. The grape is NEVER shown. You must know: red Northern Rhône = Syrah. White = Viognier or Marsanne/Roussanne.
3 Single Vineyard	Guigal's 'La La' wines — La Mouline, La Landonne, La Turque — are single vineyard Côte-Rôties. Prestigious single plots may appear here on premium bottlings.
4 Vintage	Critical — Northern Rhône is a cool climate region with genuine vintage variation.
5 AOC Declaration	Confirms appellation. Note: no grape, no blend information, no sweetness indication. You must know the appellation.
6 Bottling Note	'Mis en Bouteille par' = bottled by (not necessarily estate-grown). 'Mis en Bouteille à la Propriété' = estate-bottled.

Southern Rhône — Châteauneuf-du-Pape (Grenache blend)



1 Château/Domaine	The estate name. 'Château' is used in the Southern Rhône even though it's not Bordeaux — same word, different region.
2 Papal Symbol	The traditional embossed papal arms on the bottle neck or embossed into the glass — not required but used as a quality mark since the 1930s. Protects against counterfeiting.
3 APPELLATION	Châteauneuf-du-Pape — the most prestigious Southern Rhône AOC. The grape blend (Grenache-led, up to 18 varieties) is NEVER stated. The alcohol is typically high: 14.5–16%.
4 Vintage	Less critical than in the North — Southern Rhône's warm, consistent climate produces reliably good wine most years. 2016 and 2019 are recent standouts.
5 AOC Declaration	Confirms origin. Châteauneuf-du-Pape has some of France's strictest AOC rules — maximum yield, minimum alcohol, hand-harvesting in some cases.
6 Estate-Bottled	'Mis en Bouteille au Château' — estate production. The Perrin family of Beaucastel is one of the appellation's most respected producers.

■ *Rhône key: All red Northern Rhône = Syrah (except Côte-Rôtie which may include up to 20% Viognier). All white Northern Rhône = Viognier (Condrieu) or Marsanne/Roussanne (elsewhere). Châteauneuf-du-Pape = Grenache-led blend up to 18 varieties. None of this appears on the label.*

THE SOUTH — LANGUEDOC IGP: WHERE FRANCE SHOWS THE GRAPE



IGP wines break France's 'no grape on the label' tradition — making them the most accessible French labels for international buyers.

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| 1 Producer | The estate. Mas de Daumas Gassac is famous for making one of the South's most ambitious reds — sometimes called 'the Lafite of Languedoc.' |
| 2 Style (not AOC) | 'Rouge' simply means red wine. In the IGP system, there's no appellation hierarchy like Bordeaux or Burgundy. The producer's name carries the reputation. |
| 3 GRAPE VARIETIES | In the IGP system, grape varieties may appear on the label — often do. This is very unusual for France and makes IGP wines the most internationally accessible French labels. |
| 4 Vintage | |
| 5 IGP (not AOC) | 'Indication Géographique Protégée' — broader and more flexible than AOC. Allows varieties and blends not permitted in the local AOC. Many ambitious Languedoc estates use IGP to escape restrictive AOC rules. |
| 6 Estate-Bottled | 'Mis en Bouteille à la Propriété' — estate production. Same meaning as the Bordeaux and Burgundy equivalents. |

■ *The South key: IGP = more flexibility than AOC. Grape varieties CAN appear on the label. This makes Languedoc-Roussillon wines the easiest French wines for new buyers to navigate. Great value often hides here — look for IGP Pays d'Oc as your entry point to Languedoc.*